General Dyer demonstrates his failings as a political operator, especially when compared to the speeches made by Churchill and Curzon.

Unfortunately for both the Indian government and for Britain's international standing, things only finally started to change for the better after Curzon's policies proved a failure. Events in Persia, Afghanistan and India would show how potent the forces of nationalism and pan-Islamism were in the post-war years, and just how much the British foreign secretary was out-of-touch with the current climate in the region. It was only by 1922 that the British government at last abandoned the ambitious policies once advocated by Curzon for the more modest but realistic aims of the Indian government – even if it was actually Sir Percy Loraine who now represented this change of policy, rather than Delhi. Nevertheless, even after seeing his plans for South Asia collapse, still Curzon could not admit that he had been wrong. When it came to the agreement with Persia in 1919, for example, he attributed its failure to the ungratefulness of the Persian people, and the insincerity of the Persian government. It was because the Cabinet had decided to withdraw all of Britain's troops from the country and because Herman Norman was incompetent – in short it was everyone else's fault but his. When the Red Army landed at Enzeli, Curzon insisted he was not to blame, despite refusing to allow the British troops to withdraw earlier, thereby avoiding an embarrassing rout. When Muslim agitation was soothed by the Treaty of Lausanne, the foreign secretary could not admit that perhaps Britain had hitherto mishandled the Turkish – and by extension, the pan-Islamic – question. Instead, Curzon simply took it as a sign that Delhi had been exaggerating Muslim unrest. Even in the face of overwhelming evidence, Curzon was unable to open his mind to the possibility that the Indian government had been right in what it said in 1918 and to recognise that perhaps he had underestimated the strength of the nationalist and pan-Islamic feelings of the day. The foreign secretary simply could not be shifted from his stubborn adherence to a Great Game mentality.

The reason, then, that the advice of the Indian government was ignored when the Home government was forming its foreign policy towards South Asia is simple: Curzon. The foreign secretary's Great Game mentality, his stubbornness, narrow-mindedness and ambition combined with his self-